declined any part in the battle at Kannauj.[15] Besides the brothers, there was their cousin Yadgar Nasir, their uncle Mirza Haider, their various mothers, aunts, sisters and wives, and, of course, a great many chiefs of wavering allegiance.

For over two months, they held consultations, even managing to draft ‘a deed of concord and unanimity’, duly signed. Humayun delivered a rousing speech. ‘With what difficulty had [Babur] . . . conquered Hindustan – so vast a country! If through your disunion it pass from our possession into the hands of nobodies what will the wise say of you? Now is the time to sink the head into the bosom of good counsel . . .’

It wasn’t so much good counsel, however, as an outpouring of second thoughts that followed Humayun’s oration. Why not move upon Sindh, proposed Hindal and Yadgar Nasir, and thence to Gujarat, and thus take on Sher Shah once again? Haider, having given Humayun a rather sharp lecture on his ‘want of constancy and of purpose’,[16] said let the princes and chiefs take over the hills while Haider went to Kashmir – he would send word when the valley was his, while Sher Shah would be unable to reach the Mughals in their heights. Even better, said Kamran, what if the padishah and princes marched into the hills or Kashmir as they liked, while Kamran took their women and families to Kabul? He would return to join them, of course – only later.[17]

The meeting broke up with nothing achieved. Meanwhile, every day brought news of Sher Shah’s advance, and with it the realization that the princes might negotiate between themselves all they liked, but it was Sher Shah, the new star of Hindustan, who held their fate in his hands.

Kamran – always portrayed as the most self-serving of the four brothers – ‘out of wickedness and blindness’, writes Abul Fazl, sent a messenger to Sher Shah, offering himself as a kind of governor in Punjab. ‘I will do a good job,’[18] he promised eagerly. Sher Shah, ‘a thousand times emboldened by the good news of disunion’, accepted Kamran’s petition and sent an envoy to Lahore. The faithless Kamran organized a party for this man – sworn enemy of his dynasty! – and even ‘by entreaties induced’ Humayun to come.

We are left to imagine that Humayun treated such pitiful scrambling for crumbs with the scorn it deserved, but here – as often, when it comes to the